Topic A: Core concepts

Learning Objectives

- Explain the fundamental concepts of Topic A
- Apply the basic methods to simple examples

Content

What Makes Something a Religion?

There is no universally agreed definition of "religion" in philosophy, sociology, or law. Two broad approaches dominate the debate:

- **Substantive definitions** focus on *what a religion is*: belief in supernatural entities, sacred texts, and a community of adherents.
- **Functional definitions** focus on *what a religion does*: providing ultimate meaning, community, a moral framework, and ways of coping with finitude.

Pastafarianism satisfies many criteria on both approaches. Whether that is sufficient — given its explicitly parodic origin — is the central question of this session.

The Sincere Belief Argument

Martin (2020) argues that the decisive criterion is **sincerity**: a belief system qualifies as a religion for legal purposes if its adherents sincerely hold its tenets and are prepared to bear real costs for those beliefs. On this view, the *origin* of the belief system (parodic or otherwise) is irrelevant; only the *current attitude* of the believer matters.

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[FSM is a religion]: Pastafarianism qualifies as a religion for legal purposes.

<Sincere belief argument>

(1) A belief system constitutes a religion if its adherents sincerely hold its tenets
    and are prepared to bear costs for those beliefs.
(2) Some Pastafarians hold the tenets of Pastafarianism sincerely and have borne real
    costs (legal disputes, official complaints, social censure) for their identity.
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(3) [FSM is a religion]
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The Parody Objection

The common objection to Pastafarian claims is that the movement's explicitly satirical origin disqualifies it:

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<Parody objection>
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(1) A belief system deliberately designed as parody cannot be the object of sincere belief.
(2) Pastafarianism was deliberately designed as parody by its founder.
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(3) Pastafarianism cannot be sincerely held.
(4) A belief system that cannot be sincerely held does not qualify as a religion.
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(5) Pastafarianism does not qualify as a religion.

[FSM is a religion]
  - <Parody objection>
```

The Response: Sincerity Can Outlast Satirical Origin

Martin (2020) argues in response that the parody objection conflates the *founder's* intent with the *adherents'* belief:

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<Parody-sincerity response>

(1) A belief system may originate as satire yet be later adopted with genuine commitment
    by adherents who were not its founders.
(2) The sincerity criterion applies to current believers, not to the founder's intent.
(3) Some current Pastafarians satisfy a behavioural sincerity test: consistent practice
    and willingness to bear costs.
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(4) The parodic origin of Pastafarianism does not establish that current adherents
    cannot hold it sincerely.

<Parody objection>
  - <Parody-sincerity response>
```
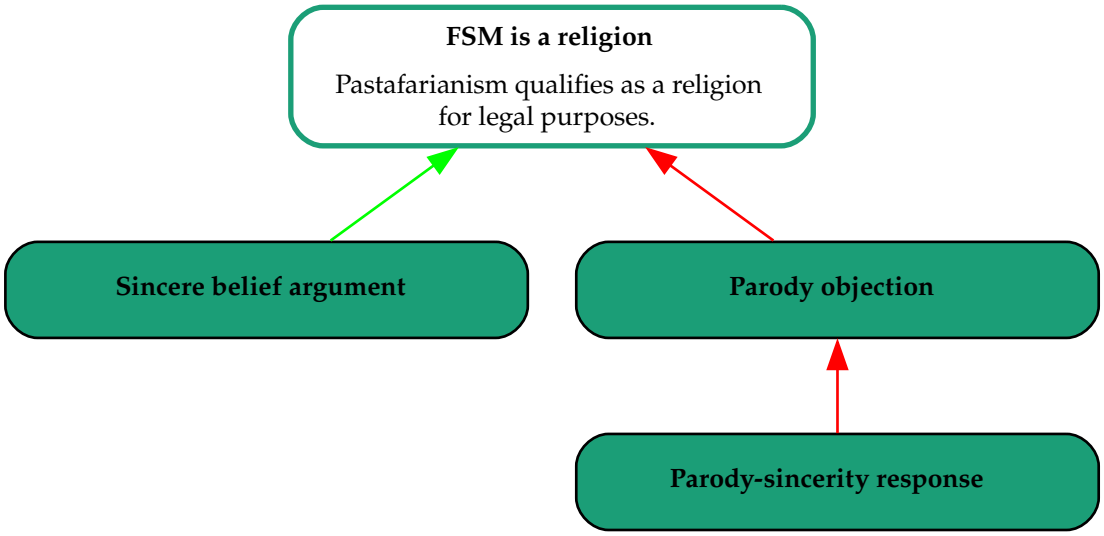

Full Dialectical Map

All three arguments in one view:



Exercises

1. **Diagram the structure.** Identify which argument supports `[FSM is a religion]`, which attacks it, and which attacks an attacker. Check your reading against the dialectical map above.
2. **Evaluate premise (1) of the parody objection.** Is it plausible that a belief system *designed as parody* can never be sincerely held? Give a real-world example that either supports or undermines this premise.
3. **Extend the map.** Add a further counter-argument to `[FSM is a religion]` that does *not* rely on the satirical origin. Reconstruct it in Argdown notation and indicate where it fits in the dialectical map.
4. **Compare definitions.** Does the sincerity test count as a functional or a substantive definition of religion? Justify your answer in 3–5 sentences, citing Martin (2020).

References

Martin, Nick. 2020. "Exemptions, Sincerity and Pastafarianism." *Journal of Applied Philosophy* 37 (2): 258–72. https://doi.org/10.1111/japp.12386.